The Dilemma of a Ghost: Summary and Analysis

A Short Summary

The “Dilemma of a Ghost” by Ama Ata Aidoo is a drama about a young Ghanaian graduate (Ato) whose arrival with his fiancée (Eulalie) in Africa causes problems that would later put him in a dilemma. The constant confusion between Ato’s family and Eulalie is a result of cultural differences and societal expectations of how a wife should behave.

The dilemma of a ghost centres around Ato Yawson, a Ghanaian who recently completed his studies in the United States and returns home with an American bride, Eulalie.

From the beginning it is clear that Eulalie isn't like the girls back home, and that there is potential for conflict here. Already in the opening scene, a short prelude, Eulalie and Ato are arguing. Still, here there seems hope that love can conquer all -- at least that's how the two feel. But one of the big issues they will face is already addressed here: Eulalie isn't eager to bear children yet, though it is expected of her and Ato that they will begin a family as soon as possible.

Eulalie doesn't quite fit into the African lifestyle. Ato, the scholar, is highly regarded for his accomplishments, but there are also expectations on him now, and it is difficult to balance them with wilful Eulalie's needs and desires.

The action of the play is spread out over a year. Over the entire time

Eulalie can't accustom herself to African customs and life. She turns to alcohol, and continues to do much as she pleases, rather than adopting the position expected of her. She doesn't fit in -- a situation that seems impossible to remedy.

The drama starts with a prelude followed by 5 ACTS thus, ACT 1, 2, 3, 4 and 5

Characters in the Dilemma of a Ghost

Ato: A Ghanaian graduate and the main character.

Eulalie: African American Woman (Ato’s fiancée)

Esi Kom: Mother of Ato

Monka: Ato’s sister

Nana: Ato’s grandmother

Akyere: Ato’s elder aunt

Mansah: Ato’s younger aunt

Petu: Ato’s elder uncle

Akroma: Ato’ s younger uncle

1st woman and 2nd woman: Ato’ s neighbours

Boy and Girl: Two children in Ato’ s dream.

Summary of Prelude

The prelude begins with a poem that seems to arouse our interest in what the reader is about to experience. Next, In a dialogue, Ato (a young Ghanaian graduate) and his fiancée Eulalie (an Afro-American graduate) have a lovely discussion with each other. They seem to be in love and are planning to move to Africa to live there. Eulalie cannot wait to meet Ato’ s people and have the African experience. Her only concern is with her plan to postpone childbirth until she’ s ready but Ato assures her it wouldn’ t be a problem.

Summary of Act (1)

Two neighbours in Ato’ s village, 1st woman and 2nd woman discuss the topic of childbirth while returning from the river. They later change the topic to talk about the arrival of Ato from abroad and other matters relating to Ato’ s family. As usual, Ato meets with the whole family after his arrival to discuss family matters, but issues get out of hand. When Ato announced that he was married to a woman from another land, all the family members were surprised and displeased with the news. Nana particularly was unhappy about Ato’ s choice of life partner.

Summary of Act (2)

Act two begins with 1st woman and the second woman debating on the topic of childbearing, where 1st woman laments her inability to give birth. Later, Esi Kom, Monka and Ato became the topic of discussion. They commented on Monka’ s (Ato’ s sister) inability to get a good husband. Their next discussion was on Ato’s refusal to marry a native but rather a stranger. Moving on, Ato and Eulalie are having a good time in Africa as they have a chat about outdated cultural practices such as witch-hunting. Near the end of Act 2, Eulalie brings up the topic of childbirth again but Ato brushes it off and says they should stick to their original plan of postponing childbirth.

Summary of Act (3)

{Ato and Eulalie comes to spend a weekend in the village}

In the Ato has a strange dream while having a siesta. In his dream, he saw a Boy and a Girl singing a song about a ghost. Next, Petu (Ato’s Elder Uncle) comes to visit Ato where they talk about Ato’ s dream. Esi Kom and Monka were the next to visit Ato. Things go very wrong when Eulalie throws away the snails Esi Kom brought for Ato, describing the snails as horrible creatures. This creates an unpleasant tension between Ato, Eulalie and Esi Kom. Esi Kom complains bitterly about how unfairly she was treated when she visited Ato in Accra.

Summary of Act 4

{Another 6months later, Ato and Eulalie visits the village once again}

It starts again with 1st woman and 2nd woman discussing about the sprinkling of stools in the village. Again, they switch topics to Ato's family matters. They hint that even though Ato is back from abroad Esi, her Mom still lives a poor life. They are concerned that Eulalie uses modern equipments which they refer to as "machines" to do all her house chores. They even suspect that Eulalie might be barren. 1st woman comments, "If it is real barrenness, then, oh stranger-girl, whom I do not know, I weep for you." Later, the family visits Ato to ask him why his wife has not given birth. They even suggest bathing Eulalie stomach with a medicine to help her give birth. However, they left the place very upset because Ato insisted there was nothing wrong with his wife. Eulalie was frustrated because Ato refused to tell his family about the real reason why they hadn't started a family.

Summary of Act 5

The following morning, Ato and Eulalie are supposed to go to a thanksgiving service but Eulalie refuses to go. Ato is not pleased that Eulalie is drunk on a Sunday morning but Eulalie shows no concern. Eulalie in her drunken state insults Ato's people calling them bastards and savages who lack understanding. Ato gets angry and slaps Eulalie on the cheeks. Eulalie leaves the house and is nowhere to be found. Ato goes all around searching for her. Ato in his search finds himself knocking on his mother's door. Ato explains to his mother that Eulalie is gone. He also reveals that, Eulalie is not barren and that they had planned to postpone childbirth until they were ready. Esi Kom upon learning this secret blames Ato for all the confusion and misunderstanding they had with Eulalie. She then had empathy and understood Eulalie better. Fortunately, Eulalie made her appearance In the middle of the conversation. Esi Kom upon seeing how miserable she was, took her inside the house. Ato was then confused as to where he went wrong. In the end, he was in a dilemma because he didn't know what to do. Should he follow them or should he go to his room?

Questions and answers on the Dilemma of a Ghost in the Cockcrow.

1. What is the conflict in the Dilemma of a Ghost?

ANS: The conflict arises as a result of the cultural expectations of how a wife is supposed to

behave.

2. What does the Dilemma of a Ghost talk about?

ANS: It talks about the return of Ato with his fiancée, Eulalie, from the United States of America and problems which arise as a result of cultural differences.

3. Why was Eulalie not having a child?

ANS: She was not ready to have a child

4. Who are Mansa and Akroma in the story?

ANS: Mansah is Ato’ s younger aunt and Akroma is Ato’ s younger uncle

5. Who is the master scholar in the Dilemma of a Ghost?

ANS: Ato

6. Who is Ebow?

ANS: Ebow is a young Ghanaian graduate and also the main character.

7. Who was the Ghost and what was his dilemma?

ANS: In Ato’ s dream, a boy and a girl sung about a ghost. In the lyrics of the song, a ghost was in a dilemma of whether or not to go to Elmina or capecoast.

8. What are the main themes of the dilemma of a ghost?

ANS: 1. Cultural differences 2. Tolerance 3. Marital conflict

9. Explain how Ato’s mother, Esi Mom, felt about her son returning home with an African-American wife.

ANS: She felt that she was an unlucky soul

10. What literary device can be found in the statement, “Already, naughty slumber is stealing over my senses”?

ANS: Personification

11. Narrate Ato’s dream in your own words.

ANS: He saw a Boy and Girl singing about a confused ghost as to which direction to go

12. What did Nana mean by saying, “Ato, do not talk with the foolishness of your generation?

ANS: She meant that Ato was ignorant of ancient wisdom.

13. In the story, who was known to have “the hardest mouth” in their town , and why was this person described this way?

ANS: It was Monka because she was known for talking too much.

14. Why did Eulalie throw away Esi Kom’s gift and how did that action reveal her character?

ANS: She threw away the gift because she was disgusted by it. It reveals that she was disrespectful or unappreciative.

15. What was Esi Kom’s intention when she gave the gift to Ato and Eulalie?

ANS: She intended to please them with the gifts

16. Where did Eulalie come from?

ANS: The United States of America

17. Why did Ato slap Eulalie?

ANS: She called Ato’s people savages with no understanding.

18. Why was Ato’s reason for not telling his family the truth about his plan to delay childbirth?

ANS: He said they wouldn’t understand

19. Who informed Maami that Eulalie had thrown away the snails?

ANS: Monka

20. When did Ato have his dream?

ANS: On a Saturday afternoon.

21. What was Nana’s reason for disapproving Ato’s marriage?

ANS: She claimed Ato had married a slave which she found unacceptable.

22. Mention the three major clans stated in the prelude.

1. Obrumankoma

2. Odapadjan

3. Osun

23. What was Ato’s family remedy for the childlessness of Eulalie?

ANS: They wanted to wash Eulalie’s stomach with medicine and pour libation to drive away evil from Ato and his wife.

24. What is the name of the second woman?

ANS: Aba

25. What suggestion did Nana give to Akroma concerning her wife’s stomach?

ANS: He told him to take her to a herbalist in Kofikrom

26. What was Esi Kom rearing in Ato’s name and why did she sell the sheep?

ANS: She was rearing a sheep and she sold it to save some money for Ato’s bride price.

27. State one proverb in the drama.

ANS: One must take time to dissect an ant in order to discover it’s entrails.

28. What opinions did 1st woman and 2nd woman have concerning childbirth?

ANS: First woman claimed that childbirth was always profitable while 2nd woman argued childbirth was not always profitable.

29. Who is referred to as the daughter of slaves?

ANS: Eulalie

30. What was Eulalie’s reaction to the drum roll in Africa?

ANS: She was really scared because she thought it was witch-hunting.